

PARROTS AND COCKATOOS

Most parrots are birds of tropical forests, although a few favour open habitats. This order, the Psittaciformes, is diverse and often colourful.

The most recognizable feature of a parrot is its decurved bill. Both mandibles of the bill articulate with its skull: the upper mandible can move up, just as the lower can move down. This allows the bird not only to crack open hard seeds and nuts, but also to use its bill for gripping when clambering through trees. The legs are strong and the feet, with two forward-facing and two backward-facing toes, can grasp and manipulate foodstuffs. Bright colours are common, often in both sexes, with green plumage predominating. This colour is the result of feather structure,

which scatters light on yellow pigment. The Australasian cockatoos – parrots with a distinctive erectile crest – lack this feather texture and so lack green and blue colours.

Australasia's high parrot diversity, which includes the brush-tongued, nectar-feeding lorikeets, suggests that the group originated in this part of the world. The most primitive parrots, the kea and the nocturnal, flightless kakapo, are both found in New Zealand.

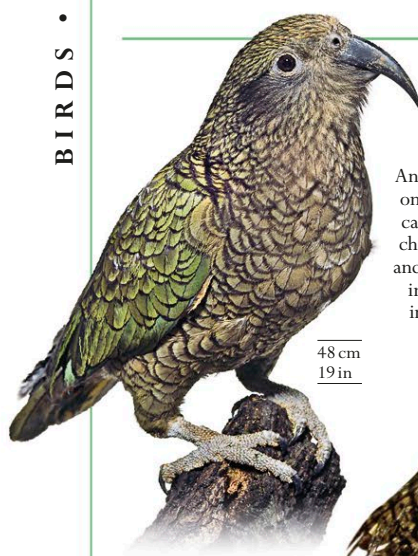
SOCIAL SPECIES

Parrots are sociable, often living in large flocks, and almost all species form strong pair bonds. Their engaging personalities make them popular as pets, but the international cagebird trade has driven many species to the edge of extinction.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PSITTACIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	398



Green-winged macaws socialize at a clay lick, which provides sodium in an area where the mineral is very limited.

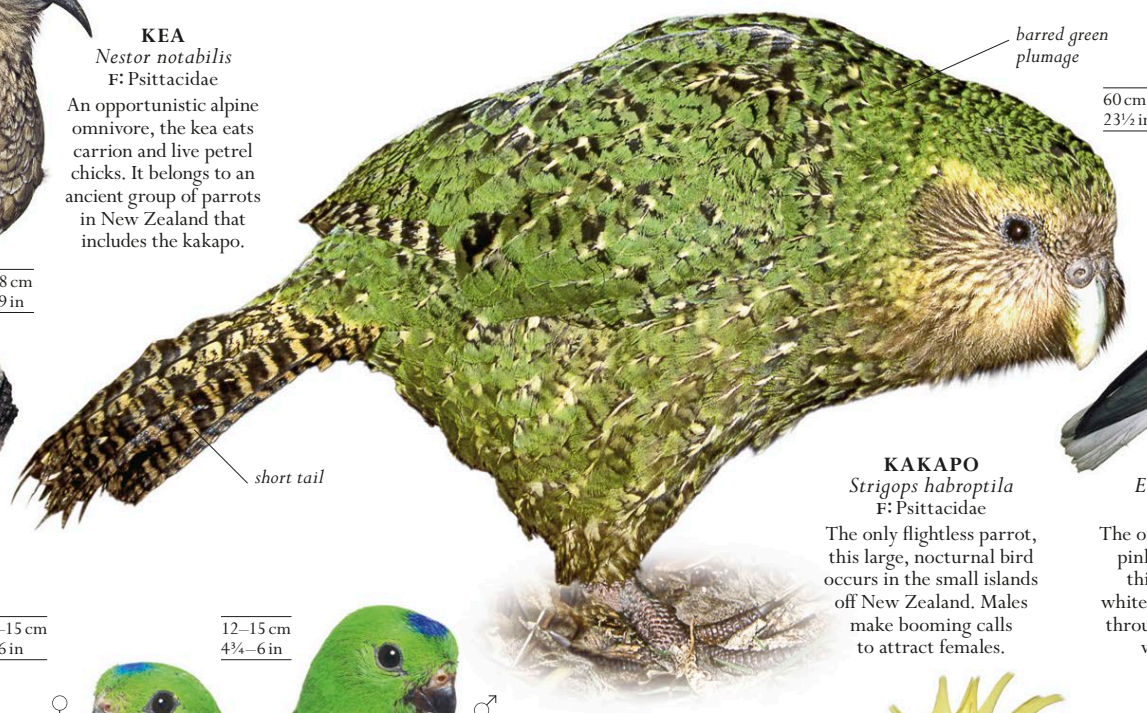


KEA

Nestor notabilis
F: Psittacidae

An opportunistic alpine omnivore, the kea eats carrion and live petrel chicks. It belongs to an ancient group of parrots in New Zealand that includes the kakapo.

48 cm
19 in



barred green plumage

60 cm
23½ in

short tail

KAKAPO

Strigops habroptila
F: Psittacidae

The only flightless parrot, this large, nocturnal bird occurs in the small islands off New Zealand. Males make booming calls to attract females.



36 cm
14 in

GALAH

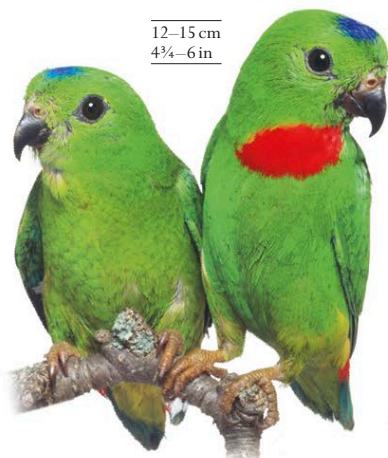
Eolophus roseicapilla
F: Psittacidae

The only cockatoo with a deep pink neck and underparts, this small relative of the white cockatoos is widespread throughout Australia in areas with scattered trees.



13–15 cm
5–6 in

♀



12–15 cm
4¾–6 in

♂

VERNAL HANGING PARROT

Loriculus vernalis
F: Psittacidae

Hanging parrots are Indo-Pacific birds, even though recent genetic evidence suggests affinities with African lovebirds. This species is found from India to Thailand.

BLUE-CROWNED HANGING PARROT

Loriculus galgulus
F: Psittacidae

Hanging parrots, unusually among birds, sleep upside down. Like other such parrots, this small forest bird from S.E. Asia has a short tail and mainly green plumage.



49 cm
19½ in

SULPHUR-CRESTED COCKATOO

Cacatua galerita
F: Psittacidae

White cockatoos are screeching parrots with a range that extends from Indonesia to the Pacific Rim. This species occurs in New Guinea and Australia.



50–61 cm
20–24 in

RED-TAILED BLACK COCKATOO

Calyptorhynchus banksii
F: Psittacidae

One of several Australian black cockatoos with coloured tail panels, this glossy species has a typical wailing call and ponderous wing beats.